



TRACK RECORD & LEADERSHIP

## Thirteen Commercial, Operational and People Systems, Each Rebuilt From the Ground Up

Twelve years of P&L ownership, seven of them across five divisions and a national affordable housing operation: c.80 people, nine direct reports and a 250-office delivery network. In that time I grew divisional revenue more than fourfold, held a 23% return on sale across a £1.1bn development pipeline while the industry average fell from 15% to 10%, and returned a business unit earmarked for closure to sustained profit. The structures behind each of those are still running.

**4x**

divisional revenue growth

**23% ROS**

sustained

**£1.1bn**

GDV pipeline

**100%**

account retention



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## Growth & Structure

Four different engines for winning new business, or rescuing one that had stopped.

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# Structural Alignment: A Business Development Engine Built to Scale

Thirty business development managers. Thirty-eight estate agency regions I didn't manage. Five new-homes divisions I did. This is how those three worlds were aligned into one structure, and one £1.1bn pipeline.

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**£1.1bn** GDV pipeline, contracts secured

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## Situation

Thirty business development managers covered thirty-eight estate agency regions, and the model had a hole in it. National and regional housebuilders operating across several patches heard different pitches, different fees and materially different service levels from the same company, which cost credibility on exactly the accounts worth most. Underneath that sat a bigger gap: my BDMs and the estate agency regions that would ultimately sell the stock had no formal alignment and no shared reporting line. Growth depended on how entrepreneurial an individual happened to be that quarter, which meant it could not be forecast, could not be protected when someone left, and could not be scaled. For a business setting a budget, that is the real cost. Not lost revenue, but revenue nobody can responsibly commit to.

## The Leadership Challenge

The real difficulty wasn't designing a better process. It was that the two populations who needed to work as one, my BDMs and the estate agency regional managers, sat in entirely different parts of the business, under entirely different leadership, with no shared reporting line to fall back on. I couldn't instruct thirty-eight regional managers to prioritise my BDMs. I had to make it worth their while to choose to.

So I aligned the two structures directly, though never as a rigid one-to-one grid. A dedicated BDM covered every regional manager's patch, so no region ever shared a BDM with another, but a single BDM might hold two regional managers' patches where seniority and patch volume justified it: a junior BDM typically ran around six branches, a mature BDM up to twelve. That was the territory design underneath everything else: coverage sized to what each person could actually carry, with a shared incentive to grow the same ground together. The alignment itself, not a memo and not a mandate, is what made the rest of the structure work.

## Approach

### Skin in the Game, on Paper

The pairing model didn't run itself cleanly from day one. Wherever a patch underperformed, the instinct on both sides was to blame the other: not winning enough from my side, not selling it well enough from the agency side. That pattern got bridged with documentation, not discipline: sensible handover documents at every stage that signposted exactly who owned what, so both sides kept skin in the game rather than a convenient excuse when a number came in short.

### The Win:Sell Model

I built the commercial logic that made the alignment worth it. My team won the instruction; their branch sold it, off the back of buyers and sellers their agents were already meeting every day, an indirect channel to market I could never have replicated by building my own network from nothing. The incentive ran both ways: the more my team won, the more stock they had to sell; the more they sold, the more they wanted to help win the next one. It was cyclical in a bigger sense too: a developer happy with how a site had sold was a developer more likely to hand over the next instruction, in that location or another, a continuous virtuous circle rather than a

series of one-off wins. On the largest accounts, dedicated on-site resource carried the heavy lifting directly with the client day to day, but that resource was line managed by my own team throughout: recruited, trained and performance-managed by my BDMs and Directors, who drove the sales and customer satisfaction result behind them. Client dialogue at the level that mattered sat with my BDMs, Directors and me more than with on-site staff, though always on a transparent basis: nothing to hide, so a client was free to speak to whoever was actually dealing with their project. League tables made the results visible, and visibility did the rest: branches that had never proactively passed on a lead started doing it on their own initiative.

## **Lanes, Not Chaos**

Alongside the alignment, I set clear rules for who approached whom, the coverage model that made thirty individual BDM relationships behave like one business. National PLC developers, whose regional boundaries usually crossed several of my BDMs' patches, were coordinated centrally, approached Regional Sales Director to Sales Director, timed around their half-year and full-year reporting, so the business spoke to them with one voice instead of several. SME developers were owned directly by the local BDM who knew them best. The handful of true national relationships came to me or my direct reports personally. Wherever an account sat, the standard of service behind it was now the same.

## **A Land Team, Not a Land Grab**

The old approach to winning an instruction was, in effect, a generic offer to sell houses, nothing to distinguish it from any other agent, a relationship sell that depended on luck or persistence. I built a small land team whose only job was sourcing land opportunities and bringing them to preferred developer partners before anyone else could. Bringing a developer an opportunity they didn't already have changes the entire conversation: it's no longer a favour I'm asking for, it's one I'm owed. That reciprocity is what won the sales-agency appointment on the homes eventually built there, and it opened cross-sales the old cold-pitch approach never could.

## **Built the Layer, Rather Than Hired It**

Regional sales managers on the largest accounts were recruited from inside the business and grown into the role, each running a number of sites and reporting directly to me. That was deliberate. Internal promotion gave me people who already understood the operating model, cut ramp time to near zero, and created a visible progression route that made the roles underneath easier to fill and easier to keep. Building a management layer is slower than stretching one person across dozens of live sites. It is also the only version that survives the person who built it.

## **Result**

c.£1.1bn of GDV under contract across a 4,000-unit pipeline, built through thirty designed relationships across thirty-eight regions rather than thirty individual efforts. The commercial effect was not only volume. Pipeline became forecastable for the first time, which changed what the division could credibly commit to at budget: a number solid enough ahead of time to justify investing in the team and the land pipeline with confidence, rather than reacting to whatever business happened to land that quarter. The cost of winning fell too, because an agency network of c.250 offices started generating leads it had never previously bothered to pass on. It kept producing after I stopped holding it together personally, which is the only real test of whether it was ever a system. For the client, the change was just as visible: a national housebuilder now dealt with one commercial position and one service standard wherever they operated, rather than negotiating separately with four parts of the same company.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-bdm-structure.html>

## Redesigning Pay to Redesign Growth

A pay model built on revenue rewards holding on. This is the story of redesigning incentives so that letting go was the profitable choice, without ever paying out for a mandate that was never going to work.

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**4x** divisional revenue growth, seven years

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### Situation

For years, variable pay was tied to the revenue running through an account rather than the outcome of it. That sounds reasonable until you follow the incentive. Once someone won a mandate, their income depended on that revenue continuing to flow through them personally, so when the moment came to move delivery to whoever could actually run it best, they had every reason to resist. Sincerely, not obstructively: the pay structure gave them every reason to believe they could do it better themselves, and every reason not to find out otherwise. The cost never showed up as a failure to win business. It showed up as growth capped at whatever a handful of people could personally hold onto, a ceiling built into the pay model rather than into the market or the team.

### Approach

#### Paying the Milestones, Not the Revenue

I rebuilt variable pay from the ground up around the actual lifecycle of a mandate rather than the revenue it eventually produced. Twenty-five per cent on signature, once due diligence was complete. Twenty-five per cent when the first invoice cleared. The remaining fifty per cent only when the home itself sold. Pay stopped following the money through the business and started following the moments that actually mattered.

#### Why Fifty-Fifty, and Not Some Other Number

The split itself was the entire design problem, and it had to survive one specific test: it could not reward winning a bad mandate. Front-load the payments too heavily and you'd be paying people well for instructions that were never going to sell, rewarding failure, in effect, just dressed up as new business. So half the reward sat on outcomes the BDM directly controlled: winning the mandate, clearing due diligence, getting the first invoice out, because that's exactly the behaviour growth needed more of, and it's controllable, so it was fair to reward it early and with confidence. The other half stayed tied to the sale itself, which depends on none of that being enough on its own: the meetings, the shared sales strategy, the quality of the project set-up, the coordination with branch and regional managers that actually gets a home over the line. Someone could bank the first half quickly. They could only bank all of it by staying properly engaged until the account actually delivered.

#### Capped, Not Cut Off

The structure also had to survive what happened when money that looked earned never actually arrived. Commission was clawed back if income was never received into the business, because paying out for a result that didn't happen is reward for failure dressed up as incentive. But a clawback landing at the wrong moment, at Christmas, say, can do real damage to someone who has already spent against it. So the initial commission element was capped rather than paid in full up front, with the balance held back and released as further invoices actually cleared: protection for the individual, not just the business. I also modelled a maximum of 60% of any invoice paid out in commission at any one time, on the basis that a business this size still needed positive cash flow, and I ran it as carefully as if it were my own. In practice the cap rarely bit. The largest share

of commission on a deal almost always banked in one go, because the first invoices tended to land together, so the protection sat underneath the structure as discipline rather than something a BDM ever felt holding them back; when it did apply, waiting for the next invoice was all it took to release the rest.

## **Modelled Before It Was Trusted**

None of this could be rolled out on instinct. A pay-model change touches every deal in flight, at every stage, and the business had to know, not hope, that it could sustainably fund the new structure regardless of deal size, timing, or how quickly a home actually sold. I built the financial modelling for the redesign across dozens of scenarios before a single contract moved onto it: fast sales and slow ones, small mandates and large ones, clusters of deals landing at once and quiet quarters where they didn't. Only once the numbers held up under all of that did it go live.

## **Getting It Approved, Then Landed**

The case went to my Managing Director, but approval wasn't the only bar it had to clear. I took the modelling to finance to confirm there was no jeopardy to the company in any of the scenarios it would have to survive, and worked through implementation with HR, who flagged what the modelling alone couldn't: a changeover period, with deals already running on the old structure and new ones starting on the redesigned one at the same time. Managing that overlap properly, rather than forcing a hard cutover, was as much a part of getting the change live as the pay model itself.

## **Result**

Divisional revenue grew more than fourfold over seven years, c.£1.9m to c.£8.2m, and held through a cyclical market rather than riding a rising one. Three things matter commercially about how that was done. It was cost-neutral, funded entirely from the existing variable pay envelope with no increase to the cost of sale. It was modelled before it was trusted, stress-tested across dozens of deal scenarios so the business knew rather than hoped it could fund the structure at any mix of deal size and timing. And it never paid out for a mandate that was never going to sell, because half the reward stayed tied to the home actually completing. The behaviour changed before the revenue did. Mandates started moving to whoever could deliver them within days rather than being held for quarters, which shortened time to revenue on every new win and meant the person running a client's account was the person best placed to run it. The structure is still in use, largely unchanged, years later.

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Read this story online: [https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story\\_pay-redesign.html](https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story_pay-redesign.html)

# Winning the Contract Before the Relationship Can Help You

A twenty-year relationship earns you an invitation. Then you are scored on paper by evaluators who have never met you and are not permitted to care that they might have.

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## Scored on Paper

public and institutional procurement, won on evaluation rather than access

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### Situation

Relationships win a great deal of business, but a significant share of what I was responsible for could not be won that way. Housing associations, local authorities, institutional funds and government-backed programmes buy through formal procurement: prescribed processes, published evaluation criteria, scored written submissions and, increasingly, weighted ESG criteria.

In that world, access counts for nothing. A twenty-year relationship earns you the right to be invited, and then you are scored on paper, against everyone else, by evaluators who may never have met you and are not permitted to be influenced by the fact that they might have. It is a different discipline from a pitch and it rewards a different set of skills.

### Approach

#### Led the Submissions Personally

As company lead on the business's formal bid submissions, including government tenders, I owned the commercial position, the pricing model and the quality response rather than delegating the number and reviewing the words afterwards.

#### Wrote to the Criteria, Not to the Story

Submissions were built against the published evaluation weightings rather than against what I most wanted to say. A tender is not a pitch, the marker is not the audience, and points are only available where the scheme says they are available.

#### Made Operational Depth the Differentiator

The understanding built up on a live account, down to viewing numbers, staff attendance and sale trajectory on individual sites, is exactly the evidence a competitor cannot assemble inside the six weeks a bid window allows. On the largest account that depth compounded every cycle, to the point where competitors were functionally excluded. Not through any exclusivity clause, but because years of accumulated detail cannot be matched with weeks of preparation.

#### Priced for Position Where That Was the Right Call

Including taking a landmark instruction at breakeven in its first phase as a deliberate decision to establish market leadership, then renegotiating terms once the position was proven. Market position first, margin second, and only where the position was genuinely worth buying.

#### Bid Governance, Not Bid Enthusiasm

A clear qualify-or-decline decision before anyone wrote a word, so effort went into bids the business could win and deliver rather than into every opportunity that arrived. Qualify-or-decline governance before commitment, and evaluation-led writing throughout: bid risk managed as a discipline rather than pursued on optimism.

## Writing Commitments Somebody Would Have to Honour

ESG commitments are scored, and they are also contractual. Anything I wrote into a submission became an obligation the moment the bid was won, so I designed the governance for it at the same time as the commitment itself: what evidence had to be captured, who owned capturing it, and when it would be reviewed. Then I held the sign-off against delivery.

Commitments written to win a tender and left unmanaged afterwards are a liability that surfaces in year three, usually in front of the client. Designing the tracking at the outset is what turns a scoring exercise into something the buyer actually receives.

## Result

Substantial contract wins with housing associations, private developers, local authorities and institutional funds, and the largest account in the group retained in full through every tender cycle of the relationship. The commercial insight is that a well-run account is a compounding asset in procurement: each cycle the submission got stronger because the operational understanding underneath it got deeper.

Procurement discipline also travels further than almost anything else on this site. Bid governance, evaluation-led writing, pricing strategy and ESG commitments are the same disciplines whether the buyer is a housing association, an NHS trust, a local authority, a framework body or a corporate procurement function. It is the part of my experience that is least specific to property and most specific to how large organisations actually buy.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-procurement.html>

## Rescuing a Business Earmarked for Closure

A loss-making Scottish unit wasn't short of revenue, it was carrying cost that had grown disproportionate to it. This is the story of fixing that first, then rebuilding the pipeline that took the unit from loss to one of the division's stronger performers.

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**Loss → Profit** a unit earmarked for closure

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### Situation

I inherited a standalone Scottish business unit that was loss-making, to the tune of a six-figure annual loss, and formally earmarked for closure. It was not short of revenue. The cost carried against that revenue had grown disproportionate to it: contracts with client commitments, press spend and staff wages baked in regardless of how a site was actually performing, and a management layer that had grown heavy enough to make decisions without contributing to them. In every practical sense it was a country manager's problem in miniature. A geographically separate unit with its own cost base, its own client relationships and its own reputation in a market that knew it was struggling, a group centre that had run out of patience, and an open question about whether it had a future at all.

### Approach

#### Diagnosing Before Cutting

The first job was understanding the contract base properly, not assuming it was uniformly bad. For every site, the question was the same: was it selling, and if not, why? Where the marketing strategy was right and stock still wasn't moving, the issue sat with the developer, which meant going back to them to negotiate on house price. Where the strategy itself was wrong, I fixed it directly. Only once that distinction was clear did I decide, contract by contract, whether to keep it, renegotiate it, or exit it, and some contracts were exited.

#### One Outcome Was Certain. The Other Wasn't.

The rate card needed the same scrutiny as the contracts underneath it. Holding fees where they were, with volume as thin as it was, made one outcome close to certain: the business would close. Raising fees carried real risk of its own: if it cost the little business the unit still had, the business might close anyway. But "might" and "certain" are not the same bet. Standing still guaranteed the outcome I was trying to avoid; raising fees only risked it. Framed that way, there was only ever one rational answer, so I raised the rate card, and made sure every fee earned from it could be justified against the value actually being delivered.

#### Rebuilding the Cost Base Site by Site

The unit had been carrying the full staff cost on every developer site, regardless of what that site could actually support: the same cost to serve applied everywhere, whatever a site could bear. I went through each one individually. On some, staff stayed on-site because the volume justified it. On others, I pulled people off-site and sold from local offices instead, in line with the [Win:Sell model](#) used elsewhere in the business. On the rest, staff remained on-site, but the contract was renegotiated so the developer carried the cost of them: the business kept management control, without carrying the cost of a presence the site alone couldn't justify.

#### A Management Layer That Wasn't Managing

Restructuring at that scale is a process, not a decision. I mapped the roles the business genuinely needed against what good looked like, matched existing people into that structure wherever there was a direct fit, and ran proper consultation where there was not. Some people left. Handled badly, that is where a turnaround stalls, because the people who stay are watching how the people who go are treated. Handled properly, and

with the reasoning explained rather than announced, it is what allows the team that remains to believe the change is about the business rather than about them. That was never headcount removed to hit a number, and it was never presented as one.

### **Anchor Wins to Prove What Was Possible**

With the team set, the focus moved to winning the right type of business. I set the standard for the team, then went and found the anchor developments myself. The Victoria, the regeneration of the former Victoria Hospital in Glasgow ([see the case study →](#)), was one. The sale of homes on the old football stadium site in Paisley was another. Both did double duty: proof to other developers of what the business could deliver, and proof to a team that had stopped believing it could win, of exactly how.

### **Making It Stick**

The wins were the turning point, not the finish line. What followed was trade and coaching sessions run consistently, the Win:Sell model driven hard rather than left to adopt itself, and a structured cadence of one-to-ones and quarterly reviews put in place, the same discipline that runs the business today.

### **Result**

The unit moved from a six-figure loss to a six-figure profit, becoming one of the division's stronger performers, on a cost base that finally matched its revenue and a pipeline built on anchor instructions rather than hope. Three things made it durable commercially: the rate card rose and held, the contract base was profitable contract by contract rather than only in aggregate, and the fixed cost of a site presence was matched to what each individual site could actually support. Reputationally, landmark wins such as the Victoria in Glasgow proved the recovery to the market rather than only to an internal board, which is what stopped competitors treating the unit as an easy account to take. For clients, a supplier they had every reason to worry about became one they could plan around. The recovery earned promotion to Divisional Director.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-scotland-turnaround.html>

## Holding Margin While the Market Squeezed It

UK new-build completions fell a cumulative 10.2% over three years, yet return on sale held at 23%. Four levers, pulled at once, protected margin a shrinking market wouldn't hand over on its own.

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**23% ROS** return on sale, sustained

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### Situation

Over 2023–2026, the UK private housing and new-build sale market faced a severe downturn: a cumulative 10.2% drop in completions since the end of the Help to Buy scheme, with persistent quarterly output contractions reported by the Office for National Statistics throughout.

In a buoyant market, the easiest way to improve return on sale is simply to sell more: once volume passes a certain threshold, incremental income is largely profit, after variable pay and tax. That lever is what most businesses lean on. It barely works when the market itself is contracting: there aren't enough buyers left to sell your way to a better margin. Protecting return on sale had to come from how the business was run, not from volume the market wasn't going to give up.

### Approach

#### Paying for What Used to Be Free

The business had been giving away site boards and hoarding as a cost of winning instructions: a small, unrecovered expense on every account, and a habit that added up across the whole portfolio. I flipped it, but not with a flat invoice. The developer paid in full, on the basis that it was their development and ultimately their cost to carry, but because I had a vested interest in seeing it sell, I framed it as a shared one: a genuine 50/50 split on an item like £20k of flags and hoarding, with my share rebated back to the developer in stages rather than handed over up front. On a 50-unit scheme, that might mean a quarter rebated at invoice 13, another quarter at invoice 15, and so on through the programme. It did four things at once: it bought real loyalty and demonstrated commitment rather than just asserting it; it protected cash flow on larger accounts by keeping cost ahead of the rebate rather than the other way round; it supported a higher fee, justified by the perceived value of the commitment; and it kept the developer contractually tied in, since walking away meant forfeiting money they were still owed. The principle behind this, and every other cost decision through the downturn, was simple. Don't cut to hit a number, treat the purse as if it's your own.

#### An Unfair Share of a Shrinking Market

I pushed productivity per head hard, grinding in the idea that everyone found one per cent more each day. It sounds small. Compounded across a whole team, every day, it wasn't. I won more mandates than the market's own contraction would predict, which meant more opportunities to sell even as the overall pool shrank: taking more than a fair share of a smaller pie, rather than a fair share of a shrinking one.

#### Fees Worth Holding Out For

I held out on fee negotiations rather than discounting to win work. The best agent's services are worth paying for, but that price has to be earned, not asserted. It came either through consultative advice genuinely demonstrated on pricing and go-to-market strategy, or by bringing the developer a land opportunity directly, the same land-team approach behind the business development structure elsewhere in this business. Fee discipline without something to justify it is just stubbornness; with it, it's pricing power.

Clients pushed back on it, more than once. I held firm anyway, as a point of principle rather than a one-off negotiating stance: conceding on one account, however reasonable it looked in isolation, is what every other client eventually hears about, and flex shown once becomes flex expected everywhere. A discount agreed under pressure on a single account was never just that account's discount.

## **Transferring the Cost, Keeping the People**

I restructured commercial terms so staffing costs were billed directly to clients, sometimes at a lower headline fee to get the structure agreed. That is risk transfer rather than cost-cutting: the cost, and the exposure sitting behind it, moved to the client relationship, while the business remained the employer, retained management control and carried the HR burden. A lower fee line that transfers real risk off the balance sheet is a better deal than a higher one that does not. That is a contracting judgement rather than a pricing one, and it is the same judgement in any business that sells a service delivered by people: where the cost sits, where the risk sits, and whether the two are in the same place.

Two further levers ran alongside these: [turning marketing and research from cost centres into fee-earning products](#), and [taking a direct stake in financial-services income](#) that added an average £560 per sale to the P&L at close to zero marginal cost, one of the cleanest routes to a higher return on sale there is.

## **Result**

A sustained 23% return on sale, held for three years while industry-average returns were squeezed from 15% to 10% in the same market. The gap widened rather than narrowed. None of it came from selling more into a market that was not there to sell into, and none of it came from cutting the delivery standard, which is where margin usually gets found, and by far the most expensive place to find it. Client-reported satisfaction held across the same period, which is precisely what protected the fee level at the next tender round: a discount conceded in a downturn is very hard to win back, and a service level conceded is harder still.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-margin-control.html>

## Bringing New-Homes Business Back to an In-House Function

Countrywide Mortgage Services (CMS), the group's own financial services arm, existed the whole time, but the new-homes division routed almost all of its mortgage and protection business to outside providers instead. This is how that referral stream was brought back in-house, and why the harder part wasn't the client at all: it was persuading a function that didn't report to me.

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**+£560** average added per sale, at close to zero marginal cost

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### Situation

CMS, the group's own financial services arm, existed the whole time. It wasn't a capability the business needed to build or a provider it needed to find: it already sat inside the same organisation, under a different part of the matrix. And yet the new-homes division routed almost all of its mortgage and protection business to outside providers instead.

The reason wasn't inertia. CMS's existing model had grown up around a different kind of buyer and a different kind of transaction, and it had never been reshaped around new-build, off-plan purchases, the specific rhythm of reservation, exchange and completion a new-homes sale runs on. Every referral sent externally instead was income leaving a group that already had the capability to earn it, just not yet in a form the new-homes business could actually use.

### Approach

#### Winning Trust Inside the Matrix

This wasn't a vendor negotiation. CMS had its own leadership, its own priorities, and no reporting line to the new-homes division asking for change: the same structural problem that ran through every account built on influence rather than authority, except this time the account was internal. Nobody could be instructed to build a bespoke service model for a division that had, until now, sent them almost no business.

The case had to be made in commercial terms CMS's own leadership would recognise: not a favour, but an opportunity: an entire referral stream that had been leaving the group for years, available to bring in-house if the service model changed to fit it. That reframing, from a request to an opportunity, is what actually moved the conversation.

#### Understanding Why the Referrals Left

The perception wasn't wrong to start with. Outside providers were built around PLC housebuilders: strict discipline from offer acceptance through to exchange, a rigorous qualification process on every buyer, better reporting and real transparency. What that discipline actually cost the group was the income itself, leaving for a standard the business could build in-house just as well.

#### Building a Service Model That Actually Fit

Restructured the deal with CMS from the ground up: the service model, the reporting, the transparency, rebuilt to match the standard outside providers had set. Working groups ran on SLAs to hold that standard once it was live, not just at launch. Then integrated the offer directly into the sales process itself, raised at the point a buyer was already committing, not chased afterwards as a separate referral.

## Telling a Breach From a Recording Lag

Most of what looked like an SLA breach on mortgage-offer timelines wasn't a service failure at all, once I looked properly. It was a recording problem: offers were being logged manually, and the lag in that showed up in the data as CMS missing a deadline it had actually hit. I pushed for the system to pull live information directly rather than rely on someone keying it in after the fact. That single change did more than tidy up the reporting. It cut the noise from false breaches out of the working groups' time, so the focus stayed on the SLA breaches that were real.

## Structuring the Incentive

Structured so the division shared in the income the change created: an internal revenue share rather than a one-off favour, which is what made the change durable rather than a single win that faded once the goodwill did.

## Result

£560 average added per sale at close to zero marginal cost, on income that had been leaving the group entirely, with four of five divisions ranked in the group's top four of thirty-six for cross-sell, and conversion from house sale to mortgage sign-up averaging 35% across my divisions, reaching 43% in the strongest, against an 18% average across the group. An internal revenue share rather than a one-off favour, which is what made it durable, plus direct oversight of a service standard the business had only ever trusted to a third party before.

Mortgage and protection advice built around the specific rhythm of a new-build, off-plan purchase rather than a standard high street process, and offered at the point the buyer was already committing rather than chased afterwards as a referral. The customer outcome and the commercial one were the same decision.

The harder of two parallel wins from the same period: [research and marketing turned themselves around on a smaller, more tactical scale](#) →

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-countrywide-financial-services.html>

## Turning Research and Marketing Into Profit Centres

Two standalone cost centres, Market Research and Marketing, treated as necessary spend with no expectation of a return. This is how both were turned into self-funding income streams instead, and why the harder part was never the pricing.

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**£15,000** per research report, developer by developer

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### Situation

Market Research and Marketing were run as pure overhead inside the business: cost lines with no expectation of a return, in a period when every line of cost was under scrutiny. Neither function had ever been asked to justify itself commercially; both existed because the business needed them, not because either one earned its keep.

That made both an obvious target the moment budgets tightened. A cost centre with no revenue attached to it is the easiest line on a P&L to cut, and cutting either one would have weakened the sales operation they quietly supported: research that shaped where and how developers were pitched to, marketing material that helped win the pitch in the first place. The problem wasn't that the spend was wasted. It was that nobody had ever built a case for why it wasn't.

### Approach

#### Making the Business Case

Turning a cost centre into a profit centre isn't a pricing exercise, it's a change in how a function is allowed to think about itself. Market Research had always been produced for internal use, a document that informed decisions but was never treated as something with value outside the building. Marketing material was billed nowhere, absorbed into overhead because no single piece of it was ever worth invoicing for individually. Both needed a genuine change in mandate before either could change its numbers.

The case for change had to be made twice over: to the teams themselves, who had never been measured on revenue and had every reason to be sceptical of suddenly being asked to generate it, and to the wider business, which needed to trust that charging developers for Market Research and Marketing wouldn't damage relationships built over years of providing both for free.

#### Market Research: Selling What Used to Be Free

Changed the format the Research team produced, from an internal briefing document into a polished, developer-facing report worth paying for, and started selling it directly, up to £15,000 a time, developer by developer. Training was rolled out to every BDM, not just on pitching the price but on using the data itself: building the kind of mature, evidence-led client conversation that stood out from a crowded field of competitors reciting the same generic pitch. A report is only worth what someone can be persuaded to pay for it, and that persuasion had to happen on the front line, not from a desk.

The report itself needed a translator between the analyst who built it and the developer who had to be persuaded to pay for it: technically sound wasn't the same as sellable, and closing that gap sat with me, not the Research team.

Not every client bought a single report and moved on. Some, Zen Housing among them, bought on a standing basis: a regular subscription to basic reports that let the relationship be billed monthly rather than report by report, with bespoke work upsold on top of it. Zen Housing alone was worth £36,000 a year on that basis, and the ongoing engagement it created ran well beyond the fee itself: £1m of downstream sales followed from staying in that conversation rather than selling a single report and disappearing.

## Knowing When Not to Charge

Not every report went out priced. Some were worth more given away: where the relationship or the wider account justified it, an ex gratia report bought more goodwill than the invoice would have earned in fees. Left to individual judgement, that call would have been made differently by every BDM in the business, so I built the system that governed it instead: clear criteria for when a report was sold and when it was given, held to a standard the whole team worked from rather than decided case by case on the day.

## Tracking It Through to the Sale

Once the model was proven, I extended it across the business and tied it into the CRM rollout already reshaping how the sales side worked ([see the Governance Cadence story →](#)). That meant a report's use could be followed the whole way from the pitch to a signed mandate, not just counted as a sale in isolation. Wates is the clearest example of it working: research reports kept the conversation live through the planning phase of a site in Mold, long before any instruction existed, and that sustained engagement is what ultimately won the pitch for Maes Gwern, a £1.1m mandate in combined agency and financial-services fees. The visibility changed the conversation more broadly too: conversion from pitch to mandate secured rose, and contracted value where a report had been used as leverage in the pitch reached £11m over three years, £3m of it in the first half of 2026 alone.

## Marketing: The 10% Levy

Marketing material produced on a developer's behalf had always been a cost too small to bill for individually: a brochure here, a set of hoardings there, none of it worth raising an invoice over on its own. A modest levy on every piece of material solved that: small enough not to provoke resistance developer by developer, but applied consistently enough across the volume of material the business produced that it turned into real, compounding upside.

Developer-facing brochures and scheme identity were created and billed by the Marketing team, but run and signed off at local level, not by me personally: guidelines set the standard, and scheduled check-ins with Marketing kept me abreast of what was going out. What never passed without me in the room was anything B2B: national campaigns, and the company's own brochure, website and brand identity, the material that represented the business itself rather than a single scheme. Specialists did the craft either way; where I was involved personally, the job was pace, because without someone pushing the deadline, nothing shipped on time.

## Protecting Both From the Next Round of Cuts

The commercial case did more than generate income. It changed how both functions were perceived internally, from spend that had to be justified every budget cycle to income lines the business had every reason to protect. Neither was ever seriously threatened with cuts again.

## Result

Two cost centres turned into income lines, which protected both from the next budget round rather than making them a target for it. Research reports alone sold for up to £15,000 a time, Zen Housing's standing subscription was worth £36,000 a year before the £1m of downstream sales it produced, and Marketing's levy turned a cost too small to bill for individually into real, compounding upside. Tracked through to the sale via the CRM, contracted value where a report had been used as leverage reached £11m over three years, £3m of it in the first half of 2026 alone, with conversion from pitch to mandate rising alongside it.

Developers got research they valued enough to pay for and marketing built to a consistent standard, which raised the floor on how every scheme was presented to the buyers who would ultimately see it.

The smaller, more tactical half of the same period's work: [financial services turned around the harder, more political win →](#)

## An Extra 1%, Every Day

On the business-development side, this was flying blind: contacts and mandates that lived in nothing more than somebody's own mobile phone, information that could walk out the door with them or be deleted at will. Add a site's foot traffic nobody could verify, and the business ran on trust, not data. This is the story of replacing that smoke and mirrors with a single source of truth, and building a business around what real control made possible.

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**£1.4m** year-on-year rise in new-business wins, Q1

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### Situation

There was no control over how data was recorded, or how it was used to move the business forward. On the sales side, there was no way to know how many potential buyers had visited a site over a weekend, which meant no way to have an informed conversation with the sales team about turning that interest into a sale. On the business-development side, it was more basic still: no verified record of names, phone numbers, or conversations, because none of it belonged to the business in the first place. It lived in people's own mobile phone books: contacts and mandate histories that could walk out the door the day someone left, or be deleted in an instant if they chose to. When someone said they had a mandate, the only option was to trust them.

### Approach

#### Owning the System End to End

I didn't hand this off to be someone else's project. I was involved in procuring the CRM system, negotiating the contract, designing how it actually worked, training every team on it, and running its ongoing use once it was live, the same person accountable for it at every stage, not a different owner handing it down the line. That end-to-end ownership was itself part of the wider operating model: one accountable owner for a system, not a handover chain that dilutes responsibility at every step.

#### Making the CRM the Only Way to Get Credit

Some people resisted using it, right up until the CRM's data became the business's one source of truth. Once it was, the incentive flipped on its own: if the work wasn't in the CRM, the credit for it wasn't either. Adoption stopped being a policy people could quietly ignore, and became something in their own interest to get right.

#### From Data to Decisions

Once the data was reliable, I designed the management information that ran off it, and the governance that wrapped around it: activity-point targets that gave the team something concrete to aim at day to day, not just a number to hit by month end. For the first time, the business could be seen in real time: real-time data, real-time management decisions, real-time strategic calls. And because the data was specific, coaching could be too, built on the actual evidence of where someone's activity was or wasn't converting, not on instinct.

#### Collateral Built for a B2B Audience With Consumer Instincts

At the same time, a genuinely separate piece of work, not a continuation of the CRM build, I engaged the marketing team and fully refreshed the collateral supporting the sales teams. Most people would have seen two unrelated projects running in parallel. I saw one relationship: get the data right, and the same discipline behind it would make everything built around it work harder too. What existed was serviceable but sterile: the kind of material that could have come from any institution, when the business itself was a B2B offering selling mandates to developer clients who cared intensely about how their own customers perceived them. I

produced brochures, sales packs and presentations that were professional but genuinely warm, and trained them out to give the whole business a standard to work from. They stayed adaptable by design, so the standard never came at the cost of the entrepreneurial flair some of the best people brought to a pitch.

The two pieces worked as one system, even running as separate initiatives at the same time. The standard raised the floor for everyone who needed structure to follow. The entrepreneurial were still free to be entrepreneurial. And because every pitch, every conversation, every mandate now ran through the CRM regardless of style, I could see exactly where an individual's results tracked the plan and where they didn't, and coach the gap specifically, rather than guess at it.

## **Result**

A £1.4m year-on-year rise in new-business wins in the first full quarter, with a single source of truth running the business in real time, from a site's weekend footfall to a business development manager's claimed mandate. The wider commercial value was forecasting. For the first time the division could commit to a number at budget and defend it monthly with evidence rather than assertion, which is what changes the conversation with a group centre from explanation to management. It also made coaching specific: I could see exactly where an individual's activity was and was not converting, across dispersed teams I could not physically be with, and address the gap rather than guess at it. I owned the build end to end, from procurement and contract negotiation through design, training and ongoing use, so there was one accountable owner rather than a handover chain. The same cadence still drives coaching today, which is what turns a system into a habit rather than a one-off intervention.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-governance-cadence.html>

## Owning the Number in Front of the Board

Everything else on this site sits underneath one thing: I owned the budget. This is what that actually involved, past the org chart.

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### 5 Divisions one P&L, one forecast, one accountable owner

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#### Situation

Everything else on this page sits underneath one thing: I owned the budget. Five divisions, a national affordable housing operation, c.80 people and nine direct reports, with the annual budget, the rolling forecast and the long-term growth plan all built by me and defended upward to the group. The number itself was the same one behind every other stat on this site: divisional revenue, grown from c.£1.9m to c.£8.2m over seven years.

That is a materially different job from running a function well. A function is judged on its own output. A P&L is judged on whether the number you committed to in month one is the number you deliver in month twelve, and on whether the group can plan the rest of the business around you in the meantime. Every lever described elsewhere on this site existed because that number had to be met in a market that spent three of those years contracting.

#### Approach

##### Built the Budget From the Bottom Up

From pipeline, conversion rates and an actual cost base rather than last year plus a percentage, so the number was defensible line by line before it was ever committed. A budget you cannot explain at line level is a number you will spend the year apologising for.

##### No Surprises Upward

A monthly cadence of forecast, variance and action, with the variance explained before anyone had to ask about it. No surprises upward is not a courtesy. It is the thing that buys a business unit the freedom to run itself.

##### Accountability the Full Depth of the Structure

Nine direct reports, not accountable in the same way. Five held full P&L and budget responsibility for their own patch. Two more carried KPI and budget accountability while I managed the P&L behind them. One held P&L oversight and advised me directly rather than running a number of their own, and one was purely administrative. The cadence and the evidence base were the same for everyone; what each person was actually accountable for was sized to what they could genuinely carry, so ownership did not stop at my level and reappear as a surprise at theirs.

##### Working the Matrix Deliberately

Finance, legal, marketing, HR and operations all sat outside my reporting line and every one of them was a dependency. I made the case for what I needed in the terms each function was measured on rather than in mine, which is the only version of that conversation that works twice. I also kept the three-year growth plan separate from the twelve-month budget: one told the group where the division was going, the other told them what to bank. Confusing the two is how businesses over-promise and under-invest at the same time.

## Whose Budget Was Actually at Risk

The pressure wasn't only on my own number. My clients carried real budget requirements of their own, tied to asset value rather than to my figures: they needed to bank millions of pounds a month, and missing what they had promised their own CFO caused problems on their side of the table long before it touched mine.

Understanding their budgeting process, and being instrumental in it more often than not, became as much a part of the job as building my own. It worked both ways: help a client hit the number they had promised upward, and mine held too.

## Result

Consecutive years of revenue and volume growth, delivered against budget and forecast rather than around them, through a market that contracted for three of those years. The specific credibility that buys is the freedom to be trusted with the detail rather than managed through it. A group centre that trusts a forecast stops managing the detail, which is what allowed five dispersed divisions to run at genuine pace rather than at the speed of a monthly review. Budget, forecast and long-range plan built, defended and owned: the financial discipline a board relies on rather than reviews.

That is the same relationship a country manager has with a foreign parent, and the same one a chief operating officer has with a board. The mechanics do not change with the org chart.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-board-discipline.html>

## Bringing a National Affordable Housing Operation Under Divisional Leadership

A specialist national team, a different client base, a different regulator and a different buyer entirely. This is how it was absorbed into divisional leadership without flattening the specialism that made it work.

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**760 Homes** delivered in the final year

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### Situation

Affordable housing ran as a separate national team, selling shared ownership and affordable tenures to a buyer profile, on a funding model, and against a regulatory framework that had almost nothing in common with open market new build. Different clients: registered providers, local authorities and institutional funds rather than housebuilders. Different route to market: formal procurement rather than relationship. Different buyer: often first-time, always assessed against eligibility and affordability rules before they are permitted to buy at all. Bringing it under divisional leadership meant absorbing a specialist operation into a general one without flattening the specialism that made it work.

### Approach

A small team, under ten people, already delivering but at levels that undersold what a specialist unit that size could produce. The job was growth and integration together: raise output without flattening the different buyer, different regulator and different route to market that made the team distinct in the first place.

### Winning Trust With Senior Professionals Who Didn't Report to Anyone in the Business

This wasn't a job I could run from a distance while a team executed underneath me. It was the day job as much as it was direction from above: dealing directly with senior professionals inside registered providers, local authorities and institutional funds, people who answered to their own boards and their own funding rules, not to mine. Earning the standing to be taken seriously in those conversations took real authority, not the authority of a reporting line, since none of them had one to me, but the kind built through understanding their funding conditions, their governance and their own commercial pressures well enough to be trusted with the next instruction.

Grew affordable housing from 10% to 35% of the division's revenue, a deliberate ceiling rather than a natural one: other divisions let the same income stream drift toward 70% of their own number in some instances, and grew comfortable enough on it to win proportionately less new business elsewhere. The team covered roughly half the country and still delivered close to 45% of the group's entire national affordable housing revenue, work worth something like 60–65% of everything every other division delivered across all their revenue streams combined.

### Financial Advice a First-Time Buyer Could Actually Trust

The buyer base here was overwhelmingly first-time, which made compliant financial advice close to a necessity rather than a service add-on. Integrating mortgage and protection advice into the sales process, the same financial-services integration running across the wider division ([see the Countrywide Financial Services story →](#)), mattered more here than almost anywhere else in the business: getting it wrong wasn't a lost sale, it was a buyer placed in a home they couldn't actually sustain.

## A Second Revenue Line Inside the Same Relationships

Strong relationships with registered providers opened a second revenue line beyond new-build sales. When a shared owner wanted to sell, they were required to tell their housing association first, which ran a nominations period: a window in which the HA had first right to find a buyer. HAs instructed my team to market the home during that period, and where it remained unsold once the nominations period closed, we contracted directly with the shared owner to sell it on the open market. The second stream came from stock the HAs and councils needed to move on themselves: end-of-lifecycle properties, derelict, beyond economical repair, or outside current EPC requirements, that didn't fit a standard sales process. I set up contracts through the department to handle that disposal work too.

## Result

760 units delivered in the final year, added into the divisional P&L, with a client base of registered providers, local authorities and institutional funds that tenders through formal procurement and buys on delivery evidence rather than relationship. It diversified the division's revenue away from open market cyclicity at exactly the point the open market was contracting, which is worth as much as the volume itself.

A buyer group that is by definition financially stretched, frequently first-time, and assessed against eligibility and affordability rules before they can buy at all. Getting that right is not a service question. It is whether somebody can sustain the home they have just bought, and whether public money produced the outcome it was allocated for.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-affordable-housing.html>

## Trusted Enough to Stay in the Room

Patience won the room. Understanding both businesses well enough to see where they genuinely fit together, and keeping the right conversations alive on both sides of the relationship, is what kept it.

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**c.4,500 units** c.£22.5m won personally, 35% new business overall

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### Situation

The biggest wins in this track record didn't come from a single strong pitch. They came from two different kinds of trust: staying in a relationship long after most people would have moved on to easier opportunities, and being handed national accounts run through office networks and managers entirely outside the formal reporting line, with no obligation to prioritise what mattered to those accounts.

### Approach

#### Seven Years in the Room

I pursued a landmark 500-unit conversion instruction with a major independent developer for seven years ([see the Tobacco Warehouse case study →](#)), the kind of opportunity that surfaces once, and is easy to lose to a competitor with a longer memory or more patience. I stayed in the room, kept the relationship live and the business front-of-mind, long after most people would have moved on to something that paid off faster.

#### Advice First, Delivery Second

National accounts like Sanctuary ([see the case study →](#)), Thriving (PfP), CBRE and Octopus Real Estate were held the same way every time: win the advisory mandate first, consultative B2B advice on go-to-market strategy, pricing, product mix and phasing, then own delivery, wholly accountable for the outcome. Trust built through advice is worth more, and lasts longer, than trust built through a single transaction. The same principle scaled sideways: I drove standardisation across office networks outside my direct reporting line by setting the model and targets those networks would own, not by issuing instructions they had no reason to follow.

#### Speaking Both Businesses' Language

Retention over years, not months, comes from something most account relationships never reach: a genuinely structural understanding of both sides of it. I didn't just learn what a client wanted. I learned how their business actually worked, where their pressures sat, what their own targets and reporting lines rewarded. I held the same depth of understanding of my own business, precisely enough to see where the two could genuinely interlock. That's the real skill in account leadership: not remembering a client's preferences, but seeing both organisations as systems and knowing exactly where they fit together.

#### Trickle, Not Torrent

I trained the team to manage the relationship over years, not the meeting in front of them. The instinct with a good client is to offer everything at once, early, to prove value fast. I taught the opposite: give enough to earn the next conversation, never so much that there's nothing left to bring to the one after that. A relationship that peaks in the first meeting has nowhere left to go. One paced deliberately still has reasons to keep talking years later, which is exactly how long some of these accounts ran.

#### Keeping the Conversation Alive on Both Sides

The relationship that mattered wasn't only the one with the client. I put as much effort into my own business, engaging the stakeholders who controlled the capacity, the pricing flexibility, the resource a long account actually needs, understanding exactly how my own structure connected to theirs, and keeping that internal

conversation as live as the external one. A national account is as likely to fail from internal neglect as external competition. I made sure it never got the chance to.

## Result

c.4,500 units won personally across seven years, worth c.£22.5m in fee value, with around 40% contracted and still to release against future build programmes, new-business wins up 35% year on year and every national account retained across the period, exclusive rights secured on two. The commercial point is not the win rate, it is the retention. In a business where every account is re-tendered, revenue you keep is worth materially more than revenue you win, because it carries a significantly reduced cost of acquisition and it compounds across cycles. The wins outlasted the deals that started them. And the clients stayed for a reason that shows up in their numbers rather than mine: on the largest account, the measure I was held to was customer satisfaction scored by their own buyers and reported straight to their own board, not a sales figure reported to mine.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-trusted-relationships.html>

## The Customer Was the Product

On the largest account in the group, my delivery was measured by the client's own buyers and reported to the client's own board. That changes the job permanently.

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### Board-Reported client-scored customer satisfaction, the measure I was held to on the largest account

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#### Situation

On the largest account in the group, I was not primarily measured on sales. Sanctuary surveyed its own buyers, the people who had actually bought and moved into a home, and reported those scores directly to its own board. A weak month on one site in one region did not just cost a sale. It appeared in a report that a client's board read every quarter, against a client whose name was on the door.

That reframes the job permanently, and it should. Once the customer's experience is the number, delivery quality stops being an operational nicety and becomes the commercial mechanism. It is what retains the account, protects the fee and wins the next tender. In a business where every relationship is re-tendered, the customer's experience is not a cost of doing business. It is the asset.

#### Approach

##### Trained to the Client's Standard, Not the Contract's Minimum

I learned Sanctuary's own reporting standards well enough to anticipate them rather than respond to them, and trained my site teams to the level their board expected rather than the level the contract required. If a client's board wanted to see satisfaction trending a certain way, I needed to know that before one of their regional directors had to raise it with me.

##### Designed the Buyer Journey Where None Existed

On a council-owned development company, that meant translating planning conditions, Section 106 obligations and grant funding requirements into plain answers to ordinary questions, and building the touchpoints from reservation to completion from nothing. A council operates on process, sign-off and public accountability, correctly so. A buyer wants to know when they can view, what their mortgage offer needs to look like, and when they get their keys. Somebody has to be fluent in both.

Across ten years working with Wolverhampton City Council, there was not a single formal service complaint, despite a structural tension built into the relationship from day one: a council's own pace of decision-making runs nothing like the pace a buyer wants when they're moving into their dream home, and the council held itself to heavy customer-satisfaction measures throughout. Managing that gap without it ever surfacing as a complaint is the real evidence the buyer journey worked.

##### Measuring Satisfaction for a Client Who Wanted to Be Invisible

CBRE was one of the largest clients in the business, and the relationship they wanted was the opposite of Sanctuary's: as hands-off as possible, removed from the day-to-day almost to the point of invisibility. But removed didn't mean unmeasured. Customer satisfaction still had to be reported, so I introduced Net Promoter Score as the mechanism: a measure light enough not to demand the client's attention day to day, but rigorous enough to prove the standard was being held without them ever having to ask.

##### Built Compliance That Protects the Customer, Not Just the Client

On a shared ownership portfolio funded through Homes England's Capital Funding Guide, that meant affordability assessments testing whether a buyer could sustain ownership long term rather than merely afford the purchase, income caps applied correctly, priority honoured for first-time buyers and armed forces

personnel, and an audit trail that proved every one of those before a regulator ever asked for it. Get that wrong and the exposure is not a difficult conversation with a buyer. It is a compliance finding against a publicly funded programme, and a household in a home they cannot sustain.

## **Held the Standard Where I Had No Authority to Enforce It**

Across an agency network of c.250 offices outside my reporting line, by setting the model and the KPIs those networks would own rather than issuing instructions they had no reason to follow, and by making performance visible enough that meeting the standard became the easier choice.

## **Sequenced Product and Price Around the Buyer**

Releases, specification and phasing built around what the buyer was actually purchasing, so price points were earned through product and positioning rather than pushed onto a market that would eventually push back through cancellations and incentives.

## **Visited Every Site Personally**

Not as diligence theatre. Understanding the micro-economics of a location, footfall patterns, local competition and the specific buyer profile a scheme would attract, meant a problem could be assessed and planned for before it occurred rather than discovered afterwards. That makes the whole relationship a better journey for the customer, not just a better-managed one.

## **Result**

Every national account retained. The account measured on customer satisfaction stayed the largest in the group by volume throughout, and the position strengthened at every tender because the client's own board could see the scores.

On an institutional fund portfolio, a 150-flat scheme, £42.75m of GDV, sold out entirely off-plan for £495k in fees, and a 500-unit tower, £182.5m of GDV, sold 45% off-plan for £2.365m in fees, with the remainder following inside roughly twelve months of completion. That is the cleanest available evidence that pricing and specification were right for the buyer rather than optimistic for the client, because no incentive scramble was needed at completion and no unsold stock sat on a balance sheet waiting.

On a council-backed developer, six sites sold across shared ownership, bulk investor sale and open market, with every buyer moving through the same underlying operation without ever feeling they were dealing with a council.

The commercial argument is simple and it holds in any repeat-purchase business. A sale that completes badly costs more than the one that never happened, and the customer's experience is the asset that decides whether the client comes back.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-customer-outcomes.html>

## Grow What You Can, Buy What You Can't

Nine people reported to me. Five of the six senior roles among them were filled from inside the business, the sixth came from the client side, and the ones who left went on to run sales for developers. This is how that was built, and why it was built rather than recruited.

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### 5 of 6 senior roles filled from within

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#### Situation

Regional leadership in this business is specialised, dispersed and hard to hire at level. The market for somebody who understands a developer client, a 250-office agency network and a P&L at the same time is thin, expensive and slow. Every senior vacancy filled externally costs months of momentum and carries a real risk of getting it wrong in public.

The alternative is to build the ladder so that the next person is already most of the way up it before the vacancy exists.

#### Approach

##### Five rungs, not two

Business development manager, senior business development manager, Head of New Homes, Residential Development Director, Senior Residential Development Director. Five rungs in one discipline, which means somebody is always one step below every role that matters and already doing a version of it. A structure with two levels in it forces you to recruit. A structure with five promotes.

##### Readiness demonstrated, not assumed

People on progression plans were given oversight of live projects with structured feedback rather than shadowing, and the people closest to promotion delivered the training and onboarding themselves. Running an induction is the cleanest test of whether somebody is ready to lead, because you cannot teach a job you have not properly understood.

##### Mentoring between people, not routed through me

I buddied directors to one another so the conversations that shape a career happened without me in the room. Coaching I did myself, because their performance was my number. Mentoring had to sit outside that, or it is performance management with a nicer name on it.

##### Grow what you can grow, buy what you cannot

The one senior appointment that did not come up the ladder was the Land Director, who had been my client for ten years. Major land acquisition, the finance underneath it and the judgement about which sites are worth pursuing are not capabilities a sales business develops internally. So I stopped trying to and bought them instead, a deliberate increase in headcount rather than a replacement for one already there.

#### Result

Five of six senior roles filled from inside, including two Residential Development Directors who started as business development managers, and a Senior Residential Development Director promoted from the tier below. One Head of New Homes left the business and came back a rung higher than the job they had resigned from.

The Land Director was a deliberate increase in headcount, not a backfill: a role added through strategic foresight because major land acquisition, the finance underneath it and the judgement about which sites were worth pursuing needed a dedicated seat at the table to actually execute, capability the ladder could not grow on its own. It changed the unit economics too. Materially larger sites transacted for broadly the same effort, and a bigger site carries more downstream units, more sales revenue and more cross-sold financial services behind it. One extra seat at the table, and a bigger outcome because of it.

And some of the people I developed left. Several went on to Head of Sales and Sales Director roles with developers, and then put business my way. That is the part I would point to first. Promoting your own people proves your judgement to yourself. People you trained being hired at senior level by your own clients, and then choosing to work with you again, is the market reaching the same conclusion independently.

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Read this story online: <https://nathanbutler.co.uk/story-people.html>